you can do,' but the difference would be to give the customers a 'good experience', he elaborates. 'Trust is very important in the service industry … Keep meeting them [your clients]. They do not need you when everything is all right, be there when there is a challenge.' Chandrasekaran further explains that the top twenty-four people of the company would meet for two days every month for a brainstorming session. And each of them had to meet the clients to understand how better they could be served.

Ratan's conviction that only technology would drive future growth had its pervading impact on the entire group. His early promotion of Elxsi was evidence of this. Soonawala described the impact of the chairman's unflinching belief in technology and how it influenced his business decisions at an event in Kerala. He said that had it not been for Ratan, the conglomerate would 'probably have missed out totally' on areas like 'high-tech businesses, process controls and financial services', as it would not have viewed these sectors as 'relevant for the TISCOs or TELCOs or the Tata Tea's'. It was Ratan's vision and 'initiative' that ultimately took them to 'so many new areas of endeavour', which would in the future, 'play very very significant role[s]'. TCS was one of the companies that benefited from it.

In 1995, Ratan became the chairman of TCS and the following year S. Ramadorai became its CEO. The decade since then saw a phenomenal rise in the company's turnover. By 2005, the turnover had grown fifteen times since 1996. It was also a period when the company aggressively pursued opportunities both in India and abroad. Three years after Ratan became its chairman, TCS built a software development centre in Chennai to provide information technology solutions to member companies of the American International Group, Inc. (AIG), a leading US-based international insurance organization whose then chairman, Maurice Raymond 'Hank' Greenberg, was also Ratan's friend. By 1998, TCS's estimated valuation rose to about $2.5 billion.

By 2000, the company became the largest exporter of software from India. It was also eminently successful in expanding the company's footprint abroad. It 'signed a global alliance' with US-based Chordiant Software, a 'leading provider of e-business infrastructure software', as well as with Broadvision, a US-based 'personalised e-business applications provider, to offer the latter's business solutions in India'. Delphi Automotive Systems, the world's leading automotive systems major, also